

Reading to Comprehend Main Idea or Storyline

1. Understanding the Main Idea

The main idea is the central thought or the most important point the writer wants to communicate.

Everything else in the passage (examples, details, explanations) supports the main idea.

It can usually be found:

In the topic sentence (often the first or last sentence of a paragraph).

Through repeated words, phrases, or ideas.

By asking: "What is the author mostly talking about?"

2. Identifying Supporting Details

Supporting details explain, prove, or expand the main idea.

Look for facts, examples, descriptions, or reasons provided by the author.

Distinguish between essential information (supports main idea) and extra details (interesting but not central).

3. Comprehending a Storyline (Narrative Texts)

To understand the storyline of a novel, play, or short story:

Characters – Who are the main people in the story? What are their traits?

Setting – Where and when does the story take place?

Plot – What events happen? Identify beginning, middle, and end.

Conflict – What problem do the characters face?

Resolution – How is the problem solved?

Theme – What lesson, message, or idea does the story convey?

4. Strategies for Better Comprehension

Preview the text: Read titles, subheadings, or summaries first.

Skim and scan: Skim for the gist, scan for key details.

Highlight or underline important ideas while reading.

Take notes in your own words after each section.

Ask questions: Who? What? When? Where? Why? How?

Summarize the passage or chapter to check if you captured the main idea.

5. Tips for Exams or Assignments

Always read the questions before reading the passage (for comprehension tests).

Watch out for distractors—details that are true but not the main idea.

Pay attention to transition words (however, therefore, in conclusion) that signal key points.

For literature, focus on how events are connected rather than memorizing every detail.